

PRIESTESSES AND courtesans

ANCIENT GREECE

The ancient Greek civilization emerged in the Bronze Age and declined with Rome's ascendancy five centuries later. Ancient Greek culture had a rich mythology, in which there were a number of powerful female figures, both immortal and mortal. These goddesses were idealized, worshipped, and valued just as highly as their male counterparts. However, ordinary Greek women were still considered inferior to men. Ancient Greece consisted of *poleis*, or city states, and the degree of independence experienced by women varied depending on their class and the city state they came from.

Women in the major city states of Athens and Sparta led very different lives. Spartan girls received public education (separate from Spartan boys) that included rigorous physical training. This ensured they would go on to produce strong and healthy babies, who would become great warriors. As Spartan men devoted their lives

